States, which had denied him a visa when he was the Chief Minister of Gujarat, he has been diplomatically adept at engaging the United States. Silencing both critics and sceptics, Modi had stated categorically that “relations between the two countries cannot be determined or be even remotely influenced by incidents related to individuals.”[30] He considers the Indo–US relationship one between natural allies.

Similar to the policy of his predecessor Manmohan Singh, Modi’s reading of the Asian strategic environment also is underlined by a feeling of strategic uncertainty. Modi, however, believes that this strategic flux should translate into more responsibility for countries like India. This emphasis on responsibility has been quite different from that of the previous government. Also, while Modi wants to improve relations with China, he has been forthright in expressing India’s concerns. On his visit to Japan, criticising China’s policies in the East and South China Seas, he said that some states still follow the 19th-century mindset of expansionism. He also emphasised the freedom of navigation in those seas during his speech at the UN General Assembly. However, his deliberations with former President Obama sent the strongest signals in this regard.

The joint statement issued by the two leaders underscored that peace and security in the Asia-Pacific, and China’s increasing assertiveness in the region, figured prominently in the dialogue. The joint statement expressed concerns over the “rising tensions over maritime territorial disputes” and threats to freedom of navigation and maritime security. Taking aim at China, the two leaders also “called upon all parties to avoid the use, or threat of use, of force in advancing their claims.” To achieve these objectives, the need for complementing each other’s Asia-Pacific strategies was also underlined: “Noting India’s ‘Act East’ policy and the US rebalance to Asia, the leaders